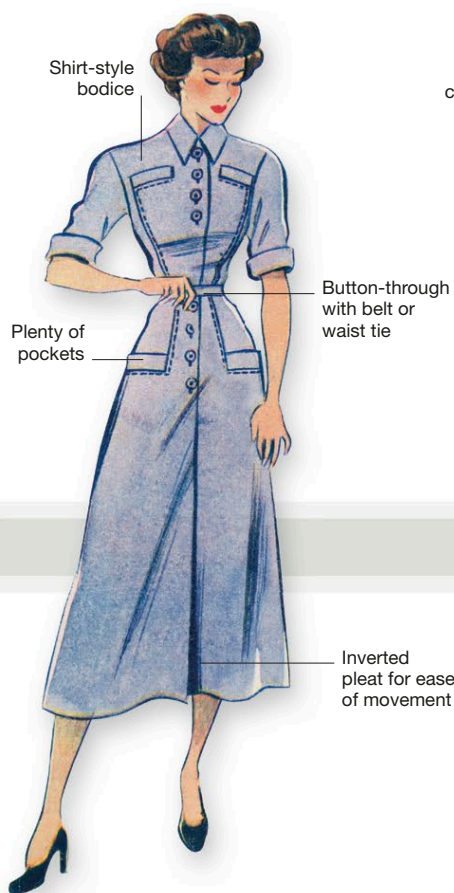




Tidy housewife A shirtdress, also called a shirtwaister, was a wardrobe staple. Practical enough to wear for doing heavy housework, it helped home-makers feel both comfortable and neat.

Wide, sleeveless cut is unrestrictive

Stand-up collar with small tie

Wide waistband creates hourglass shape

Rows of tucking add shape

1950



Patch pockets Deep patch pockets were an important feature of a house dress or casual day dress. They held essential domestic items such as clothes pegs, nappy pins, or a notebook and pen for shopping lists.



Pink and grey, a chic combination

Smart day out A dress from British ready-to-wear maker Horrockses was considered the ultimate in daytime chic in the 1940s and 50s. The brand, known for its fine-quality cottons and cheerful prints, was famously worn by Queen Elizabeth II.



1953

Style and comfort American sportswear designer Claire McCardell is remembered for her beautifully made, practical clothes, which filled a gap in the market for stylish, comfortable daywear. This ivory cotton summer dress displays the purity of line for which she was known.

CHAIN-STORE CHIC

In the US, department stores such as J.C. Penney had spread to the new suburban shopping malls by the mid-1950s. These dresses from the company's 1959 catalogue were made from a new cotton-rayon called cotron.



Catalogue advertisement, 1959